



The {tiny truth} Project

IN-SCHOOL EXPLORATIONS OF HAIKU, SHORT FORM POETRY
AND THE POWER OF MINDFUL WRITING



About NVHA

Inspiring writers, strengthening community.

The Nick Virgilio Haiku Association, with 20+ years of experience, operates the Virgilio Writers House in Waterfront South Camden NJ. NVHA is a non-profit poetry organization that celebrates poetry and its impact on communities.

Following in the footsteps of American haiku master and Camden native Nicholas Virgilio, we strive to inspire writers locally and worldwide. We offer workshops, readings, school classes and writing sessions for all ages, fostering creativity and education.

Our Local Mission

The Virgilio Writers House, home of NVHA is dedicated to providing a peaceful home for writing in Camden.

Through regular reading series, mindful haiku walks, and publication launches, we strive to be dedicated to celebrating serving our community through action. Our collaborations with organizations like Camden FireWorks, Sacred Heart, Mighty Writers and Rutgers University ensure mindful writing is accessible throughout our home city. The Virgilio Writers House is proud to be a NJ Literary Landmark, as established by the NJ Center for the Book.

Global Impact

NVHA's connection to a global community of haiku writers is pivotal to our mission. We host regular online readings, free zoom-based workshops, publication through our press Upright Remington and through our weekly insta-journal Haiku in Action.

Your support enables us to continue these vital programs, enriching and connecting lives through the power of words and creativity.



The Tiny Truth Project

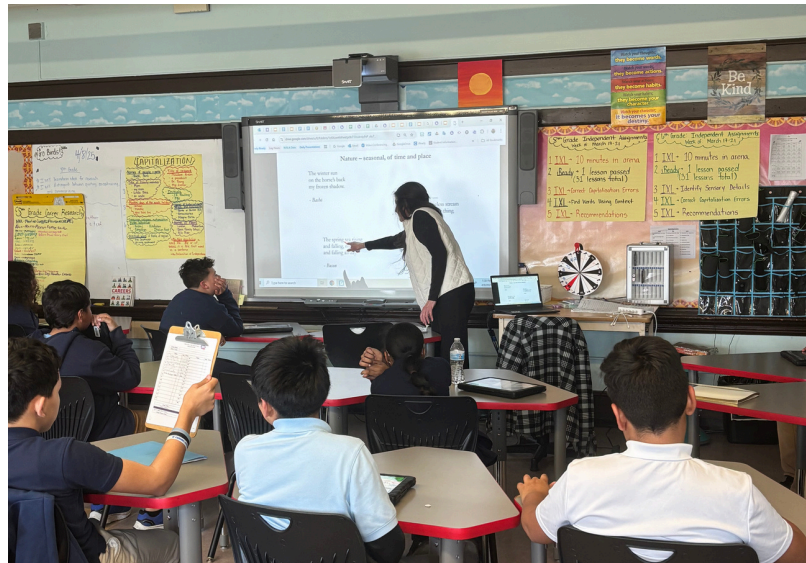
Healing Through Short-Form Poetry

Creative Mindfulness

At The Virgilio Writers House, we believe writing has the power to heal. Haiku, in particular, has an established connection with mindful attention, while also containing the building blocks of effective writing.

Through decades of youth workshops and interactions with writing teachers, we have found haiku instruction provides an accessible means to explore poetry, connect with nature and increase mindful awareness.

Built by a team of poets, curriculum developers, educators and trauma-informed councilors, The Tiny Truth Project builds on this belief and puts it to work in local schools.



autumn leaves
her last words heard
in a voicemail

Phoebe Bain — Colorado Springs, CO, Grade 12
Winner of the 2025 Nick A. Virgilio Haiku/Senryu Contest

Program Goals

1. Foster a love of writing and poetry in young minds.
2. Allow dedicated time and space for building emotional intelligence, mindfulness and reflection.
3. Equip Camden children with valuable communication skills.
4. Develop an adaptable curriculum framework for schools, workplaces and community organizations.

Why Haiku?

Mindfulness, Brevity and the Power of Short Form Poetry

Poetry invites students to slow down, observe the world around them, and express their thoughts with intention in a world that's constantly competing for their attention. Through reading and writing poetry, students strengthen their creativity, communication, and critical thinking while discovering that even ordinary moments can become meaningful stories.

Because haiku is concise and accessible, students of all writing abilities can participate with confidence, making poetry an engaging entry point into self-expression and language arts. Empirical data supports writing poetry not only as a method of self-expression, but as a catalyst for exploring complex emotions.



Haiku helps me to find the little things in life that would go unnoticed. Haiku helps me take time to think about the world around me and to just stop and perceive the small objects and motions that make my life and others around me the way it is.

Benjamin Moon-Chun — Atlanta, GA, Grade 8
Winner of the 2024 Nicholas A. Virgilio Haiku/Senryu Contest

What Research Says

Writing haiku is associated with increases in creativity and sensitivity, as it offers a structured form of emotional and symbolic expression.

- Stephenson, K., & Rosen, D. *Haiku and Healing: An Empirical Study of Poetry Writing as Therapeutic and Creative Intervention* (2015).
- Stork, B. *Haiku and Healing—Creating Connections*. PMID PMC7021139 (2020).

Writing and reading poetry is associated with positive effects on stress, depression, and emotional expression, in particular within studies focused on trauma-affected adolescents.

- *More Than Words: Why Poetry is Good for Our Health*, Arts & Mind Lab (2021).
- Stork, B. *Haiku and Healing—Creating Connections*. PMID PMC7021139 (2020).

Writing haiku is proven to help students express complex emotions and empathy, a key component of emotional awareness and interpersonal development.

- Gair, S. (2012). *Haiku as a Creative Writing Approach to Explore Empathy with Social Work Students*.
- *Thoughts, Feelings, Actions; the Brevity of Being: A Haiku ...* (Lesley University Expressive Therapies thesis).

What We Offer

Project-Based Learning for Students

Curriculum Overview

The Tiny Truth Project offers three program variations: a full 6-week, 12-session program, a one-off session and a variable length adult program.

Each session begins with a 10-minute sensory ice-breaker, nurturing creativity and encouraging emotional reflection. Students will explore imagery, concrete language, and the joy of reading poetry aloud in a supportive environment.

We provide trained instructors, course documentation, handouts and digital materials. Surveys that measure impact are also included and administered as a part of the program.

To date, thanks to the support of generous funders, our haiku series has been offered at no cost to public schools in Camden, NJ, including the books and materials relevant to the program.

Program Types	TIME LENGTH	SESSIONS	AGE RANGE
Full Program	6 weeks	12	9 - 14
One-Off	45-60 mins	1	9 - 14
Team Building/Adult Ed.	1-3 weeks	1 - 3	College +

**A dedicated high school-level curriculum is in development.*

Student-Centered Learning

This program focuses on nurturing students' self-expression and relationship with contemplative practice. The flexible curriculum caters to diverse learning styles, making it accessible for all students aged 9-14, regardless of prior experience. The project culminates in a final project showcasing their work.

The curriculum is rooted in research and has involved the participation of trained instructional developers, licensed counselors and instructors. All grade school level curricula is aligned with English Common Core Standards. While the program is intended to be administered over the course of 12 sessions and 6 weeks, our team is happy to customize the length of this program to accommodate the specific needs of our school partners.

Measuring Success

Program Impact and Timeline Overview

During the spring of 2025, this program served 51 students in Camden, NJ over the course of six weeks at Cooper's Poynt Family School and Davis Elementary School. Based on anonymous self-report surveys, we were pleased to observe up to a 45% increase in students' indicating high confidence, self-reflection, and emotional coping skills after 6 weeks engaging with the program.



For more information on TTP's results, see our Migration Analysis on nickvirgilioahaiku.org/HaikuforHealing

We want to ensure that this program continues to grow and improve for students for years to come. One of the most effective ways to understand our impact, measure alignment with program goals, and gauge the ways in which we can improve is through feedback from teachers, students, and administrators like you! **We ask that all parties involved in executing the program take short preliminary and post-evaluation surveys so the NVHA team can continue to optimize the experience.**

Over **200 students** have gone through the program since 2023.

Students showed a collective **45% increase in positive attitude towards writing** for emotional coping.

84% of students expressed experiencing feelings of joy in writing after engaging in the program.

Our success led to the Writers House **receiving the 2025 Literary Landmark Award, awarded by the New Jersey Center for the Book.**

power outage
our house
comes to life

Henry Lew — Newport Beach, California, Grade 12
Winner of the 2022 Nicholas A. Virgilio Haiku/Senryu Contest

What You Gain

Benefits of Implementing The Tiny Truth Project in Your School

For Students

- **Students learn to write original haiku and other short-form poems**, culminating in a well defined final project.
- **No previous experience in writing poetry is required.** The curriculum begins with teaching students baseline poetry principles.
- **Students develop creativity, observation, and confidence in self-expression** while exploring the world through a poet's perspective.

“ I think that in the often hectic world of my students, haiku offers a respite where they can ponder a memory or settle into the here-and-now. Condensing and compressing the language they use to convey the experience brings them a sense of wonder along with the desire to share their life experience with others. In the classroom haiku builds a sense of community, offering all the opportunity to be seen and heard.

Tom Painting — Atlanta GA
Haiku Poet and English Teacher at The Paideia School,

For Teachers

- **Lessons reinforce core english skills** like close reading, figurative language/imagery, vocabulary development, and concise writing.
- **Activities support social-emotional learning** by encouraging reflection, mindfulness, empathy, and self-expression.
- **Experienced teaching artists lead engaging, hands-on lessons** that complement the Common Core State Standards.
- The consistency of the writing practice and structure of the curriculum is **useful in ESL classrooms.**
- **Flexible lesson plans** can be adapted for students ages 9–14 and tailored to different classroom needs.

For Administrators

- **The program supports school goals** by strengthening writing and observational skills, creative thinking, student engagement, and social-emotional development.
- **Workshops are led by experienced teaching artists** from the Nick Virgil Haiku Association and can be customized to fit your school's schedule and instructional needs.
- **Rooted in Camden's literary legacy**, the program introduces students to the art of haiku while fostering meaningful connections to their own experiences and communities.

Acknowledgements

Key Contributors and Sponsors

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A Special Thanks To

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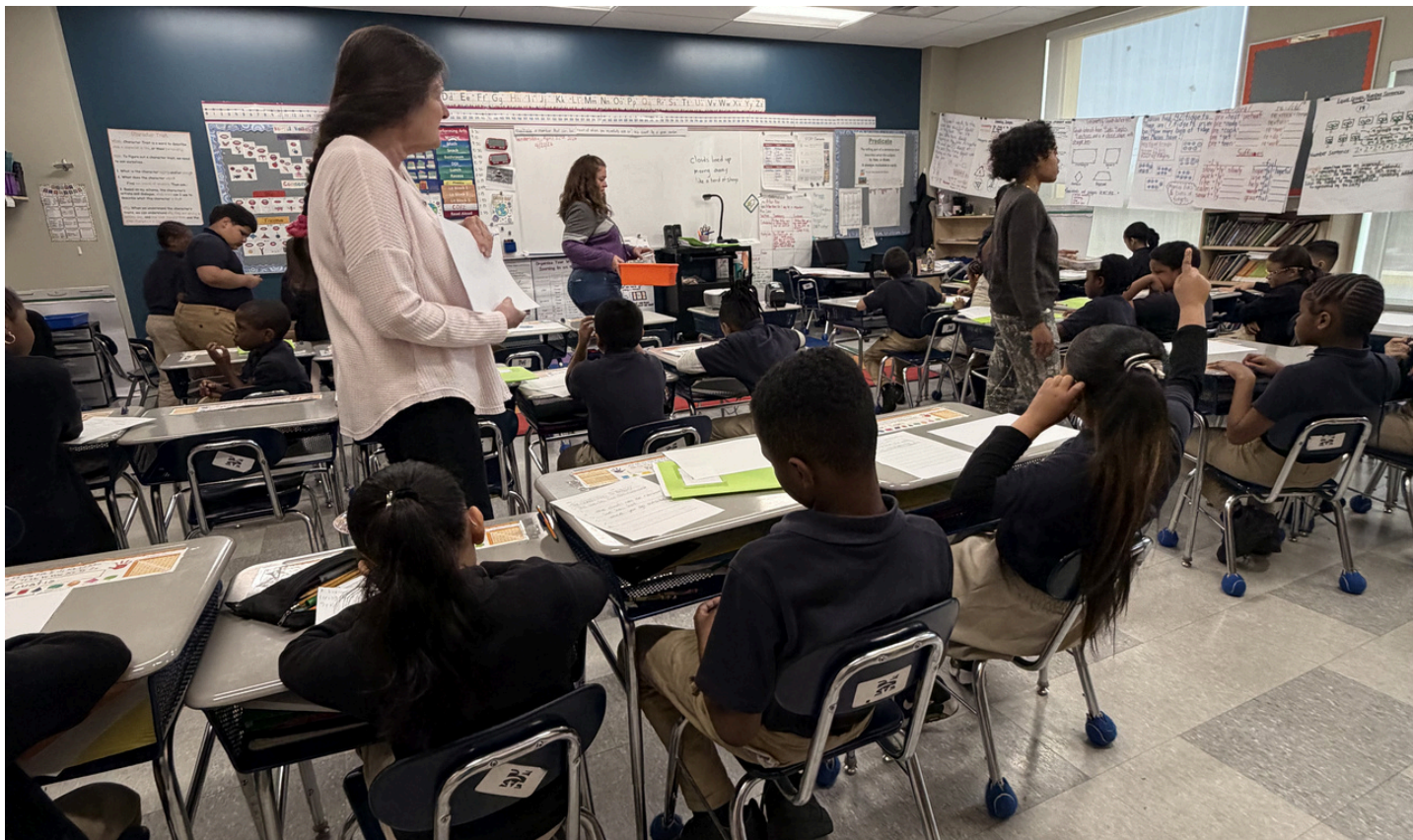
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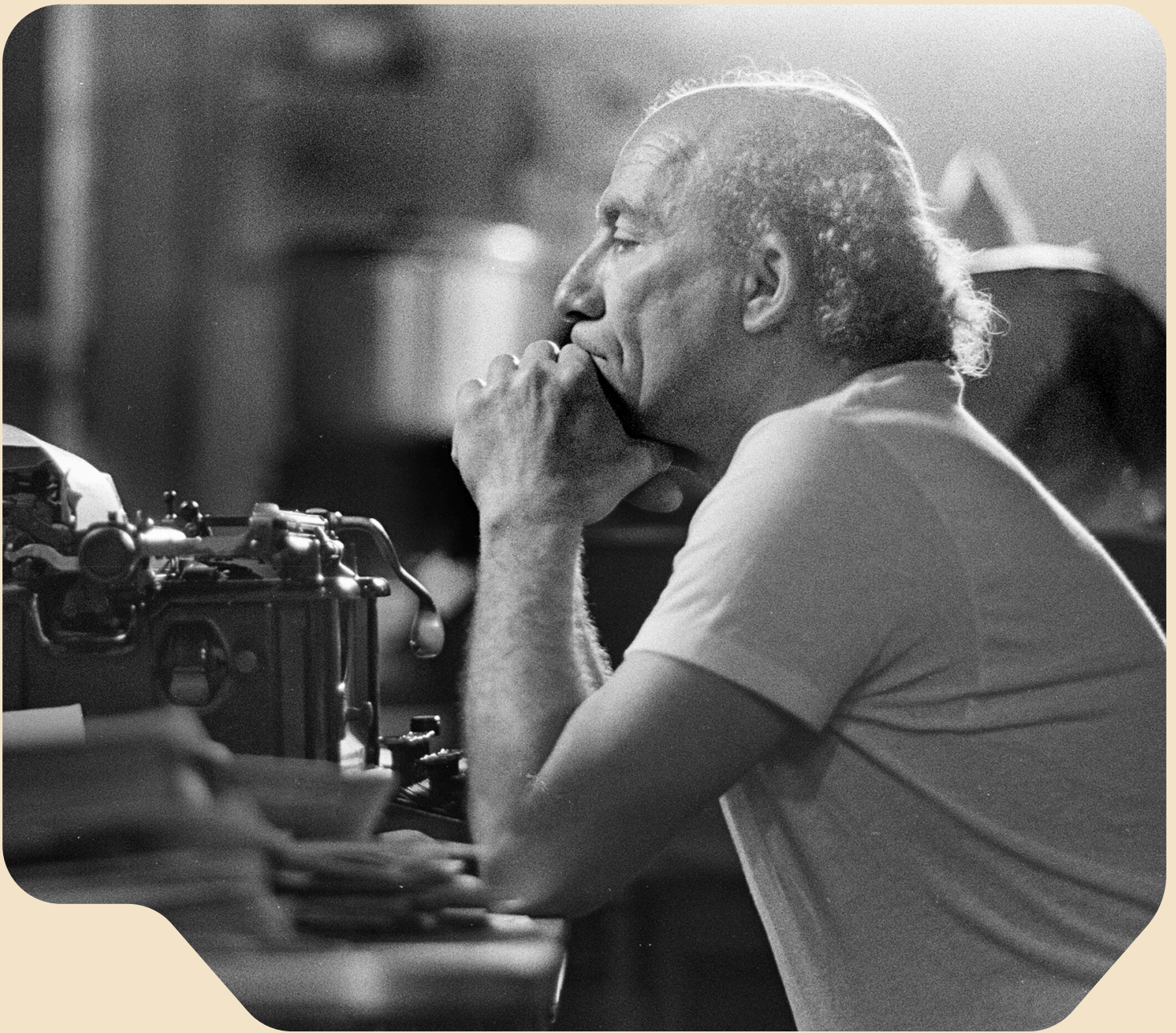
Our Sponsors

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Learn More

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